



China Primer: Human Rights

Updated September 21, 2026

Overview

The People's Republic of China (PRC or China) party-state is an increasingly repressive authoritarian regime that has engaged in widespread human rights abuses. The party-state is dominated by Xi Jinping, who became Communist Party of China (CPC) general secretary in 2012 and PRC president in 2013 and began a norm-breaking third five-year term in his Party post in 2022. Xi has enforced greater ideological and cultural conformity and tighter control over society, aided by digital technologies. PRC leaders long have asserted that human rights standards should be country-specific rather than universal, that economic development is a key human right, and that a country's human rights policies are its "internal affair."

Amid deepening repression in China, U.S. policymakers have implemented measures intended to deter PRC human rights abuses, prevent U.S. complicity in such abuses, and hold perpetrators accountable. Since 2020, among the U.S. government's priorities has been responding to reports of mass detentions and forced labor of ethnic Uyghur and other Muslim minority groups in the Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region (XUAR) and elsewhere in China. The U.S. Department of State first assessed in January 2021 that PRC policies and practices in the XUAR constitute crimes against humanity and genocide, and reaffirmed this assessment most recently in its annual human rights reports covering 2024 (the department has not yet released human rights reports covering 2025). In Hong Kong, a special administration region of the PRC, measures adopted by both central and local authorities have eroded residents' civil rights and stifled the city's civic culture and media. See CRS In Focus IF12070, *China Primer: Hong Kong*.

Selected Human Rights Issues

According to the U.S. Department of State, arbitrary arrest, detention, and enforced disappearance are "systemic" in China, and police target ethnic minorities, religious leaders and adherents, rights lawyers and activists, independent journalists, and dissidents and their families. The PRC oversees one of the world's most extensive internet censorship systems, which blocks major foreign news and social media sites, censors domestic social media platforms, and bans foreign messaging apps.

Civil and Political Rights

The PRC constitution provides for many civil and political rights, including the freedoms of speech, press, assembly, association, demonstration, and religious belief. Other provisions in China's constitution and laws, however, circumscribe or place conditions on these freedoms, and the state routinely restricts these freedoms in practice. Popular protests in China are common and often focused on local and/or economic grievances. China Dissent Monitor, an initiative by

the nongovernmental human rights organization Freedom House that tracks protest activities in China, identified 5,014 instances of dissent in 2025. Protests in China generally are quashed before becoming widespread, highly publicized demonstrations.

Rights of Religious and Ethnic Minorities

The Department of State has consistently designated China as a "Country of Particular Concern" for "particularly severe violations of religious freedom" under the International Religious Freedom Act of 1998 (P.L. 105-292, as amended). Regulations require religious organizations to obtain government permission for nearly every aspect of their operations, submit to greater state supervision, and register clergy in a national database. The government has continued to persecute practitioners of the Falun Gong spiritual group. In 2016, Xi launched a policy known as "Sinicization," by which the CPC requires religious and ethnic minorities to "assimilate" or conform to majority ethnic Han Chinese culture as defined by the CPC. In July 2026, the PRC's Law on the Promotion of Ethnic Unity and Progress, which provides a legal framework for forced ethnic assimilation, came into force. It has been criticized by human rights groups.

Christians: Researchers and advocates have reported increasing repression of Christians in China since 2025. They report that PRC authorities have shut down or demolished unregistered (or "house") churches, detained and imprisoned some house church leaders and members, appointed Catholic bishops without papal approval, mandated patriotic education and training for Christian leaders and adherents, and policed the internet activity of Christian individuals and groups, among other things.

Tibetans: Human rights issues in Tibetan areas of China include religious and political repression, forced assimilation, and the incarceration of hundreds of political prisoners. Since 2018, the PRC government has required Tibetan monks and nuns to undergo education in CPC ideology and demonstrate "political reliability." Authorities have arbitrarily detained and imprisoned hundreds of Tibetan writers, intellectuals, and cultural figures on broad charges of "separatism." PRC assimilation policies in Tibetan areas have included resettling and urbanizing nomads and farmers, policies that include elements of forced labor, according to some reports.

Uyghurs: Between 2017 and 2019, XUAR authorities detained more than 1 million ethnic Uyghur and other Muslims in "vocational education and training" facilities, also known as "reeducation" centers. Detainees generally were not accused of crimes, but rather were held on the basis of past religious, cultural, scholarly, social, and online activities, as well as foreign travel, that the government deemed "extremist," "pre-criminal," or potentially terrorist. Treatment in the centers reportedly included food deprivation, psychological pressure, sexual abuse, forced sterilization, medical neglect, torture, and forced labor. Since 2019, the XUAR government appears to

have released some detainees, prosecuted many as criminals, and sent others to work in factories. In 2026, UN human rights experts said that PRC policies to relocate millions of Uyghurs through labor transfer programs are in many cases “so severe that they may amount to forcible transfer and/or enslavement as a crime against humanity.”

Women’s Rights

The protection of women’s rights in China is uneven, and authorities sometimes harass and arbitrarily detain women’s rights activists. Facing a looming demographic crisis, the CPC in the past decade has pivoted away from its “one child” policy, which limited women’s reproductive choices to suppress population growth. It is now implementing pro-natalist policies, some of which exacerbate existing challenges faced by women, such as domestic violence, discrimination, and economic inequality, according to some observers. PRC authorities reportedly continue to conduct forced abortions and sterilizations of Uyghur women.

Selected U.S. Policy Tools

Foreign Assistance: Congressional appropriations have funded efforts to promote human rights, the rule of law, civil society, and internet freedom in China, as well as Tibet-related programs that promote sustainable development, environmental conservation, and the preservation of indigenous culture. These have included programs supported by relevant agencies as well as by the National Endowment for Democracy (NED), a private nonprofit organization funded primarily by congressional appropriations. As part of its 2025 foreign aid review, the Trump Administration reportedly terminated numerous China-related human rights programs. The Administration also sought to withhold funding appropriated for NED, prompting NED to pursue legal action to restore access to its funding.

International Media: Voice of America (VOA) and Radio Free Asia (RFA), funded by the U.S. Agency for Global Media (USAGM), have provided external sources of news and opinion to audiences in China and PRC exiles around the world. Pursuant to a March 2025 [executive order](#) targeting “unnecessary” elements of the federal bureaucracy, the Trump Administration reduced USAGM’s staffing and operations, resulting in China-related VOA and RFA service disruptions and reductions.

Legislation: Congress has enacted laws to respond to human rights developments and related issues in Tibet and Xinjiang specifically. U.S. policy toward Tibet is largely guided by the Tibetan Policy Act of 2002 (Title VI, Subtitle B of [P.L. 107-228](#), as amended). Other Tibet-related legislation includes the Reciprocal Access to Tibet Act of 2018 ([P.L. 115-330](#)), the Tibetan Policy and Support Act of 2020 (Division FF, Title III, Subtitle E of [P.L. 116-260](#)), and the Promoting a Resolution to the Tibet-China Dispute Act ([P.L. 118-70](#)). Xinjiang-focused legislation includes the Uyghur Human Rights Policy Act of 2020 ([P.L. 116-145](#)) and the Uyghur Forced Labor Prevention Act (UFLPA, [P.L. 117-78](#)). Some provisions of broader enacted bills also have addressed human rights issues in China (e.g.,

Section 7401 of [P.L. 118-31](#)). Five resolutions related to human rights in China have been agreed to in the 119th Congress.

Targeted Sanctions and Export Restrictions: The executive branch has made use of broad authorities enacted by Congress, including the Global Magnitsky Human Rights Accountability Act (Title XII, Subtitle F of [P.L. 114-328](#); implemented through Executive Order 13818), to impose economic sanctions and visa restrictions against some PRC individuals and entities responsible for human rights abuses. The United States also has imposed restrictions on the sale or transfer of U.S. goods and services to certain PRC entities for human rights reasons, pursuant to the Export Control Reform Act (Title XVII, Subtitle B of [P.L. 115-232](#)).

Forced Labor Import Restrictions: Section 307 of the Tariff Act of 1930 (19 U.S.C. §1307) forbids the importation of products into the United States that were produced with forced labor. UFLPA in part creates a rebuttable presumption that Xinjiang-related imports are made with forced labor.

High-level Diplomacy: In October 2025, PRC authorities detained pastor Jin Mingri (also known as Ezra Jin) along with several other leaders of his house church. In July 2026, following months of advocacy by Jin’s family, supporters, and Members of Congress (see e.g., [S.Res. 728](#) and [H.Res. 1259](#)), and after a May 2026 U.S.-PRC summit in which President Trump raised his case, Jin was released and reunited with family members in the United States. Some advocates have argued that President Trump’s intervention was crucial to Jin’s release. Several other members of Jin’s church remain in detention in the PRC.

Congressional Considerations

Congress may debate the overarching goals of U.S. human rights policy and the differing possible benefits, costs, risks, and likelihoods of success of these goals, as well as assess the effectiveness of U.S. actions to date. Congress may conduct oversight over executive branch actions and consider whether to accept, reject, or seek to modify executive branch policy approaches.

Relative to other Administrations, the second Trump Administration has put less priority on human rights as a U.S. foreign policy concern and has taken actions (some noted above) that appear to have curtailed certain long-standing U.S. efforts to promote human rights in China. The Administration’s immigration policies (e.g., concerning asylum seekers) may have implications for victims of human rights abuses in China seeking protection in the United States. Congress may assert its own priorities in these areas through legislation. The consolidated FY2026 appropriations bill enacted in February 2026 ([P.L. 119-75](#)) appropriated resources for certain activities to promote human rights in China that the Trump Administration has curtailed or sought to curtail.

Michael A. Weber, Specialist in Foreign Affairs
Caitlin Campbell, Analyst in Asian Affairs

IF12265

Disclaimer

This document was prepared by the Congressional Research Service (CRS). CRS serves as nonpartisan shared staff to congressional committees and Members of Congress. It operates solely at the behest of and under the direction of Congress. Information in a CRS Report should not be relied upon for purposes other than public understanding of information that has been provided by CRS to Members of Congress in connection with CRS's institutional role. CRS Reports, as a work of the United States Government, are not subject to copyright protection in the United States. Any CRS Report may be reproduced and distributed in its entirety without permission from CRS. However, as a CRS Report may include copyrighted images or material from a third party, you may need to obtain the permission of the copyright holder if you wish to copy or otherwise use copyrighted material.